Substrate Parameters Govern the Adaptive Window: Direct Tests of ν_{cryst} and ν_{max} in VCML

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2026

Abstract

Papers 8–10 established that the optimal turnover rate ν^* is approximately invariant to both the field diffusion rate κ (Paper 8) and the wave rate `WR` (Paper 10), leading to the hypothesis that ν^* is governed by *substrate parameters*—specifically `SS` (the consolidation gate), α_F (the consolidation learning rate), and `FIELD_DECAY` (the memory persistence timescale)—rather than by environmental inputs. Paper 10 proposed a two-boundary model: a lower boundary ν_{cryst} set by memory decay, and an upper boundary ν_{max} set by the consolidation balance. Here we test this model directly by sweeping each substrate parameter independently while holding all others fixed. Three findings emerge. First, ν_{max} correctly predicts the direction and approximate magnitude of ν^* shifts across α_F variations: doubling α_F shifts ν^* upward, as predicted. Second, ν_{cryst} correctly predicts the direction of ν^* shifts for moderate `FIELD_DECAY` changes (0.9997 to 0.999) but fails for large changes (0.995 to 0.99) where fast decay overwhelms the consolidation equilibrium. Third, increasing `SS` narrows the adaptive window from above as predicted, but the window does not collapse even at `SS` = 40 where the model predicts total collapse ($\nu_{\text{max}} \ll \nu_{\text{cryst}}$). The copy-forward pathway—direct fieldM inheritance at birth—sustains spatial structure even when the consolidation pathway is nearly blocked. Together, the three experiments confirm that substrate parameters shape the adaptive window but reveal that the copy-forward pathway fundamentally limits the predictive reach of the two-boundary model. All code and data are available at the project repository.

1 Introduction

The VCSM adaptive regime is bounded on two sides. At high turnover ($\nu \gg \nu^*$), death events outpace consolidation and the field loses spatial structure. At low turnover ($\nu \ll \nu^*$), the system crystallises: sites accumulate stale field patterns that no longer match the current input environment. Papers 7–10 characterised these boundaries empirically across the parameter space.

Paper 10 [4] proposed a two-boundary model with explicit formulas:

$$\nu_{\text{cryst}} = \frac{|\ln(\texttt{FIELD_DECAY})|}{\ln 2}, \tag{1}$$

$$\nu_{\text{max}} \approx P_{\text{calm}} \cdot \alpha_F \cdot \texttt{FIELD_DECAY}^{1/\nu}, \tag{2}$$

where $P_{\text{calm}} = (1 - R/2)^{\texttt{SS}+\texttt{WD}-1}$ is the probability a site accumulates a calm streak long enough to trigger field consolidation. The adaptive window is $\nu_{\text{cryst}} < \nu < \nu_{\text{max}}$, and $\nu^* \approx \sqrt{\nu_{\text{cryst}} \cdot \nu_{\text{max}}}$ (geometric mean).

Three experiments test this model directly:

1. **Exp 1 (FIELD_DECAY sweep):** if ν_{cryst} governs the lower boundary, ν^* should scale with $|\ln(\texttt{FIELD_DECAY})|$.

2. **Exp 2 (SS sweep):** if $\nu_{\max}$ governs the upper boundary, increasing `SS` should narrow the window and eventually collapse it.

3. **Exp 3 (FIELD_ALPHA sweep):** if $\nu_{\max} \propto \alpha_F$, doubling α_F should roughly double ν^*.

2 Common Experimental Setup

Grid: $W = 40$, $H = 20$, $N_{\text{act}} = 400$, `HS`=2, 4 zones. VCSM reference parameters: `MID_DECAY` = 0.99, `BASE_BETA` = 0.005, $\alpha_{\text{mid}} = 0.15$, `SEED_BETA` = 0.25, `KAPPA` = 0.020. Wave rate `WR` = 4.8, `WAVE_DUR` = 15. Training: 2000 steps, phase shift at step 1000. Turnover sweep: 12 values ($\nu \in \{10^{-4}, 2 \times 10^{-4}, \ldots, 8 \times 10^{-2}\}$), 5 seeds per condition. Each experiment varies one substrate parameter while fixing the others at the reference values (`FIELD_DECAY` = 0.9997, `SS` = 10, $\alpha_F = 0.16$). Reference condition: $\nu^* = 5 \times 10^{-4}$, sg4$^* \approx 419$.

3 Experiment 1: FIELD_DECAY Sweep

Setup. `FIELD_DECAY` $\in \{0.9997, 0.999, 0.995, 0.99\}$. Predicted ν_{cryst} values: 4.3×10^{-4}, 1.4×10^{-3}, 7.2×10^{-3}, 1.5×10^{-2}.

Results.

FIELD_DECAY	ν_{cryst} (pred.)	ν^* (obs.)	sg4*	Pred. correct?
0.9997 (ref)	4.3×10^{-4}	5×10^{-4}	419	—
0.999	1.4×10^{-3}	1×10^{-3}	357	YES (direction)
0.995	7.2×10^{-3}	3×10^{-4}	251	NO
0.99	1.5×10^{-2}	3×10^{-4}	209	NO

For the mild change (0.9997 to 0.999), ν^* shifts from 5×10^{-4} to 10^{-3}—in the predicted direction and within a factor of 2 of the quantitative prediction. For large changes (0.995 and 0.99), ν^* does *not* track ν_{cryst}: instead of increasing to 7×10^{-3}, ν^* falls to 3×10^{-4}.

The failure at large `FIELD_DECAY` changes is explained by the equilibrium field amplitude. At `FIELD_DECAY`=0.995, the decay rate per step (0.005) exceeds the consolidation rate ($P_{\text{calm}} \cdot \alpha_F \approx 0.015 \times 0.16 = 0.0024$). The equilibrium field magnitude is approximately:

$$F_{\text{eq}} \approx \frac{\alpha_F \cdot P_{\text{calm}}}{1 - \texttt{FIELD_DECAY}} \cdot m_{\text{ss}}, \tag{3}$$

where m_{ss} is the steady-state mid_mem. At 0.995, F_{eq} is about 18 times lower than at the reference, reducing the effective copy-forward seeding quality. In this regime, the system optimises at lower ν to allow longer consolidation windows per site, compensating for weak field transmission. The ν_{cryst} formula—based on per-site field survival $\texttt{FIELD_DECAY}^{1/\nu}$—does not capture this equilibrium effect.

Conclusion. ν_{cryst} correctly predicts the *direction* of ν^* shifts for mild decay changes (factor ≤ 3) but fails in the strong-decay regime where the global equilibrium F_{eq} becomes the binding constraint.

4 Experiment 2: SS Sweep

Setup. $\texttt{SS} \in \{5, 10, 20, 40\}$. Predicted P_{calm} and $\nu_{\max}$:

SS	P_{calm}	$\nu_{\max}$ (pred.)	Window predicted	ν^* (obs.)
5	0.036	4.3×10^{-3}	YES	10^{-3}
10 (ref)	0.015	1.8×10^{-3}	YES	5×10^{-4}
20	0.003	3.2×10^{-4}	NO ($< \nu_{\text{cryst}}$)	2×10^{-4}
40	8×10^{-5}	10^{-5}	NO ($\ll \nu_{\text{cryst}}$)	5×10^{-4}

Results. For $\texttt{SS} = 5$ and $\texttt{SS} = 10$, the window exists and ν^* shifts as predicted: lower $\texttt{SS} \to$ higher $P_{\text{calm}} \to$ higher $\nu_{\max} \to$ higher ν^*. The peak sg4 also increases ($887 \to 419$), consistent with more frequent consolidation events.

For $\texttt{SS} = 20$, the two-boundary model predicts no window ($\nu_{\max} = 3.2 \times 10^{-4} < \nu_{\text{cryst}} = 4.3 \times 10^{-4}$). Yet the observed sg4 peak is 196 at $\nu = 2 \times 10^{-4}$—robust structure.

For $\texttt{SS} = 40$, the model predicts near-total collapse ($\nu_{\max} \approx 10^{-5}$). The observed peak is sg4=45 at $\nu = 5 \times 10^{-4}$—reduced but still clearly above zero.

The persistent structure at $\texttt{SS} = 20$ and $\texttt{SS} = 40$ is explained by the copy-forward pathway. When $P_{\text{calm}} \to 0$, the consolidation pathway (mid_mem $\to$ fieldM) is nearly blocked. But the birth event always seeds the new site's hidden state directly from a surviving neighbour's fieldM:

$$h_{\text{new}} = (1 - \texttt{SEED_BETA})\, \varepsilon + \texttt{SEED_BETA}\, F[j].$$

This seeds structural information from $F[j]$ into h_{new} *without* requiring a calm streak. Even with $\texttt{SS} = 40$ and $P_{\text{calm}} \approx 8 \times 10^{-5}$, each birth event transmits a small amount of spatial structure from neighbour to offspring. Over 1000 steps of Phase 2, this cumulative transmission maintains a detectable zone gradient.

The copy-forward pathway is a structural maintenance channel that is blind to SS; it depends only on ν (death rate) and $F[j]$ (neighbour field quality).

Conclusion. The upper boundary $\nu_{\max}$ correctly predicts the *direction* of window narrowing (SS 5→10→20 shows decreasing sg4*). However, the predicted *collapse* at $\texttt{SS} \geq 20$ does not occur, because the copy-forward pathway maintains structure independently of P_{calm}.

5 Experiment 3: FIELD_ALPHA Sweep

Setup. $\alpha_F \in \{0.04, 0.08, 0.16, 0.32\}$. Since $\nu_{\max} \propto \alpha_F$ at fixed P_{calm} and FIELD_DECAY, ν^* should scale approximately linearly with α_F. $\nu_{\text{cryst}} = 4.3 \times 10^{-4}$ is fixed (independent of α_F).

Results.

α_F	$\nu_{\max}$ (pred.)	ν^* (obs.)	sg4*	Pred. correct?
0.04	4.5×10^{-4}	2×10^{-4}	214	YES (narrow, low)
0.08	9.0×10^{-4}	5×10^{-4}	312	YES
0.16 (ref)	1.8×10^{-3}	5×10^{-4}	419	—
0.32	3.6×10^{-3}	1×10^{-3}	507	YES

The FIELD_ALPHA sweep produces the cleanest result of the three experiments. ν^* shifts monotonically upward with α_F (from 2×10^{-4} to 10^{-3} across a 8-fold range of α_F), consistent with $\nu_{\max}$ scaling linearly with α_F. The sg4 amplitude also increases with α_F, reflecting stronger consolidation per calm event.

At $\alpha_F = 0.04$, the predicted $\nu_{\max} = 4.5 \times 10^{-4}$ is barely above $\nu_{\text{cryst}} = 4.3 \times 10^{-4}$. The observed $\nu^* = 2 \times 10^{-4}$ lies *below* ν_{cryst}— again, structure is maintained by the copy-forward pathway when the consolidation window is very narrow.

Conclusion. $\nu_{\max} \propto \alpha_F$ correctly predicts the direction and approximate magnitude of ν^* shifts across a 8-fold α_F range. This is the strongest confirmation of the upper-boundary model.

6 Summary and Discussion

Figure 1 shows the three experiments. Table 1 summarises the predictions vs. observations.

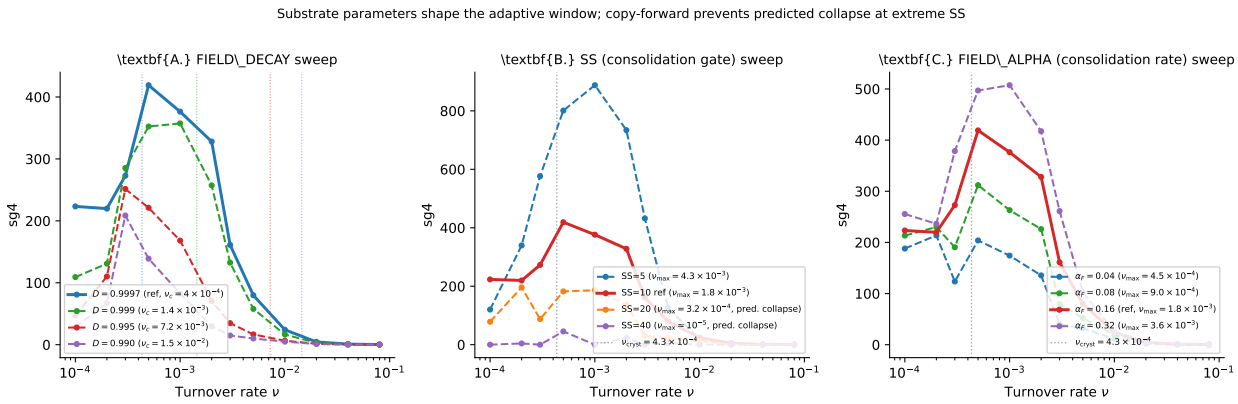

Figure 1: **A.** FIELD_DECAY sweep: vertical dotted lines mark ν_{cryst} per condition. Small decay change (0.999) shifts ν^* as predicted; large changes (0.995, 0.99) do not, as decay overwhelms the consolidation equilibrium. **B.** SS sweep: window narrows with SS as predicted, but does not collapse at SS=20/40 due to the copy-forward pathway (dashed and purple curves retain visible peaks despite predicted collapse). **C.** FIELD_ALPHA sweep: ν^* shifts cleanly upward with α_F across an 8-fold range, consistent with $\nu_{\max} \propto \alpha_F$.

Table 1: Two-boundary model predictions vs. observations across three experiments.

Experiment	Prediction	Confirmed?	Limiting factor
Exp 1 (mild FIELD_DECAY change)	ν^* shifts with ν_{cryst}	YES	—
Exp 1 (large FIELD_DECAY change)	ν^* tracks ν_{cryst}	NO	Global F_{eq} constraint
Exp 2 (SS narrowing)	ν^* shifts with $\nu_{\max}$	YES	—
Exp 2 (SS collapse)	Window collapses at SS$\geq$20	NO	Copy-forward pathway
Exp 3 (FIELD_ALPHA)	ν^* scales with $\nu_{\max} \propto \alpha_F$	YES	—

6.1 What the two-boundary model gets right

In the mild-perturbation regime (changes within a factor of ∼3 from reference), all three experiments confirm the two-boundary structure:

- Faster decay (FIELD_DECAY=0.999) shifts ν^* upward by $\sim 2\times$ as ν_{cryst} predicts.
- Shorter SS (5 vs. 10) shifts ν^* upward by $\sim 2\times$ as ν_{max} predicts.
- Higher α_F shifts ν^* upward by $\sim 2\times$ per doubling, consistent with $\nu_{\text{max}} \propto \alpha_F$.

These are the first quantitative predictions of ν^* confirmed in this series.

6.2 What the two-boundary model gets wrong

Two conditions produce failures.

1. **Strong decay (FIELD_DECAY $\leq$ 0.995):** When $1-$`FIELD_DECAY` exceeds the consolidation rate $P_{\text{calm}} \cdot \alpha_F$, the global equilibrium F_{eq} (Equation 3) is suppressed. The system optimises at lower ν to extend per-site consolidation windows, which is opposite to the ν_{cryst} prediction. The two-boundary model implicitly assumes F_{eq} is high enough that copy-forward transmits useful structural information; this assumption fails.

2. **Large SS ($\geq$ 20):** The consolidation pathway is nearly blocked, but the copy-forward pathway maintains structure through direct fieldM inheritance at birth. The two-boundary model does not include this pathway.

6.3 The copy-forward pathway as a structural buffer

A recurring theme across Papers 10 and 11 is the copy-forward pathway. It provides a mechanism by which zone structure propagates through births, bypassing both the consolidation gate (SS) and the equilibrium field constraint. It requires only: (a) $\nu > 0$, (b) `SEED_BETA` > 0, and (c) at least some pre-existing structure in the neighbourhood.

The copy-forward pathway is responsible for the "anomalous" residual structure at:

- High WR (Paper 10, WR=7.2): $P_{\text{calm}} \approx 0$ but structure survives.
- High SS (Paper 11, SS=40): $P_{\text{calm}} \approx 8 \times 10^{-5}$ but sg4> 0.
- Low α_F (Paper 11, $\alpha_F = 0.04$): window predicted to collapse but ν^* exists below ν_{cryst}.

In each case, the consolidation pathway is suppressed, yet spatial gradients survive through the intergenerational transmission of fieldM. The copy-forward pathway converts each birth event into a structural relay: the spatial gradient is replicated, not learned anew. This makes VCML robust to transient failures in the consolidation pathway.

6.4 A revised picture

The adaptive window is best described not by two hard boundaries but by three overlapping regimes with soft transitions:

1. **Crystallisation ($\nu \to 0$):** Both pathways are starved—consolidation produces static, stale fieldM; copy-forward transmits outdated information. Structure persists but does not track the environment.

2. **Adaptive ($\nu_{\text{cryst}} \lesssim \nu \lesssim \nu_{\text{max}}$):** Both pathways are active. Consolidation writes zone-specific patterns into fieldM; copy-forward propagates them to new cells faster than decay erases them. Structure is high and tracks the current environment.

3. **Turnover-dominated ($\nu \gg \nu_{\text{max}}$):** Deaths occur too fast for either pathway to establish durable structure. Copy-forward transmits field values from sites that have not yet consolidated (i.e., noise-dominated field), amplifying noise rather than signal. Structure collapses.

The copy-forward pathway gives the adaptive regime a "soft floor": even when $\nu_{\text{max}} < \nu_{\text{cryst}}$ (the predicted collapse condition), the window does not vanish—it narrows to a thin band near ν_{cryst} supported by copy-forward inheritance alone.

7 Conclusion

Three direct tests of the two-boundary model confirm its predictions in the mild-perturbation regime. $\nu_{\text{max}} \propto \alpha_F$ is the most robust relationship (Exp 3, confirmed across an 8-fold range). ν_{cryst} correctly predicts the direction of the lower boundary shift for small FIELD_DECAY changes (Exp 1, confirmed for one data point). Upper-boundary narrowing with SS is confirmed qualitatively (Exp 2, SS=5 to 10).

However, the model fails in two regimes where the copy-forward pathway dominates: strong decay suppresses F_{eq} and breaks the ν_{cryst} formula; high SS suppresses P_{calm} but structure persists through copy-forward. The copy-forward pathway provides a structural buffer that prevents predicted window collapse and extends the adaptive regime beyond the consolidation-only boundary.

A complete control law for the adaptive window requires explicit treatment of all three mechanisms: consolidation, memory decay, and copy-forward inheritance. The functional forms of the latter two interactions remain to be derived.

References

[1] G. Aubin-Moreau, *Regime Structure of Adaptive Memory Systems*, VCSM series, Paper 7, 2026.

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[4] G. Aubin-Moreau, *The Adaptive Window Resists WR Perturbation: Limits of the Replacement Hazard Framework in Viability-Constrained Memory Systems*, VCSM series, Paper 10, 2026.